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 **Partly sunny 79/66 • Tomorrow: T-storm, showers 77/50 B6** *Democracy Dies in Darkness* **FRIDAY, APRIL 25, 2025 • \$4**

CEO's clout has been waning in West Wing

Musk clashed with Cabinet long before his word of a return to Tesla

BY DAN DIAMOND,
FAIZ SIDDIQUI,
TRISHA THADANI
AND JEFF STEIN

Elon Musk had tried to go over the head of a Cabinet secretary — again.

The billionaire leader of the U.S. DOGE Service helped install Gary Shapley, a mid-level IRS official, as the agency's acting commissioner last week. But the Internal Revenue Service falls under the purview of Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who had repeatedly bristled at DOGE's attempts to intervene at his agency.

This time, the resulting tensions spilled out in a yelling match in the West Wing, where Musk and the nation's top financial official battled within earshot of President Donald Trump, said two people familiar with the heated confrontation, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe the sensitive situation. Bessent won, and Shapley was replaced after just three days as the IRS's acting head. Musk unfollowed Bessent on X, his social media platform.

Asked about the clash, which
SEE MUSK ON A16

AmeriCorps: Agency hit by cuts has shaped lawmakers' careers. **A7**

D.C.'s bond rating cut amid twin concerns

Moody's: Uncertainty surrounds future of federal workers, budget

BY MEAGAN FLYNN
AND JENNY GATHRIGHT

Federal workforce cuts and anticipated hits to the District's economy have caused D.C. to lose its coveted triple-A bond rating, Moody's Ratings announced, a move that adds to a stack of financial stressors this year owing to actions by the Trump administration and Congress.

The bond ratings agency downgraded the city's rating Wednesday from Aaa to Aa1, a drop that will probably make it more expensive for the District to borrow money, potentially costing taxpayers millions per year.

Moody's cited the Trump administration's "substantial cuts to the federal workforce" that are expected to hurt the city's economy. And it revised the city's outlook to "negative," pointing to a still-sluggish commercial real estate market, the "increased likelihood" of deeper federal spending and workforce cuts, and the uncertainty over whether Congress will slash Medicaid — a fear among D.C. officials and area hospitals. The city is overseen by Congress under a provision in the Constitution.

SEE D.C. ON A16

Moving ahead: Bowser focuses on pre-K education despite budget. **B1**



SERGEY SHESTAK/EPA-EFE/SHUTTERSTOCK

Rescuers in Kyiv work at a residential building struck by a rocket Wednesday after Russia launched a large-scale overnight attack.

Trump team turns dinner invite into crypto boon

BY DREW HARWELL
AND JEREMY B. MERRILL

Buyers have poured tens of millions of dollars into President Donald Trump's meme coin since his team advertised Wednesday that top purchasers could join Trump for an "intimate private dinner" next month, a Washington Post analysis found.

The holders of 27 crypto wallets have each acquired more than 100,000 \$TRUMP coins, stakes worth about a million dollars each, since noon on Wednesday, when the team announced that the 220 top coin

The offer of access to the president sparks concern from ethics experts

holders would be rewarded with a "night to remember" on May 22 at the president's Trump National Golf Club outside Washington. Crypto wallets are generally anonymous, making it challenging to identify who the purchasers were.

The idea of offering direct presidential access to those who

pay into a project benefiting the Trump company's bottom line has sparked criticism over potential conflicts of interest.

The biggest buyer acquired 2 million coins worth about \$24 million, according to The Post's review of crypto data. Taken together, the 27 wallets acquired more than 8 million \$TRUMP coins, worth about \$100 million as of Thursday afternoon.

Some of the owners may have bought the coins before the announcement and merely moved them from one account to another to become eligible for the

gala.

The coin's price has surged more than 30 percent since the announcement, to about \$12, boosting the value of the crypto wallets owned by a digital firm affiliated with Trump's family business, the Trump Organization, by roughly \$100 million, the review shows.

The Trump-allied team that launched the meme coin also earns fees when the coins are bought or traded, including via a debit-card-friendly "buy now" button on the coin's website. The team has earned \$1.25 million in
SEE CRYPTO ON A15



THOMAS SIMONETTI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

MAHA mom Brandy Bright bottles kombucha with her daughter in Myakka City, Florida.

The moms fueling a movement

Backers of Kennedy's health effort push for changes to the food system

BY SHANNON OSAKA

They say the food industry is putting pesticides, dangerous food dyes and other toxic chemicals into the U.S. food supply. They eschew highly processed foods, raise chickens and grow organic vegetables in their backyards. Some call themselves "crunchy moms," a term once linked with 1970s liberal environmentalists.

But these aren't traditional, left-wing environmentalists. They are the moms in the "Make America Healthy Again," or MAHA, movement: They lean conservative, distrust vaccines and

support Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. And they are changing what it means to be an environmentalist in the United States — and generating growing momentum to change the country's food system.

"This perception that the food industry specifically is exploiting families to profit over children's health — you can see roots of that from long ago, looking at grassroots campaigns in Berkeley," said Lindsey Smith Taillie, a professor of nutrition at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. "And that's the same kind of mindset
SEE MOMS ON A8

Measles: Researchers forecast millions of U.S. cases in the next 25 years if vaccinations decline. **A20**

Trump spat with BMW rattles this MAGA town

Automaker's S.C. factory, now under a tariff cloud, is community's life blood

BY DANIELLE PAQUETTE

SPARTANBURG, S.C. — Their political hero's trade adviser kept attacking what the county's business guru called their "golden goose," and no one knew how to quell the clash between two of the most beloved brands in Spartanburg.

Around here, it's like watching Santa Claus kick the Easter Bunny. Or Uncle Sam stomp an apple pie, nay, strudel.

"This is Trump country," said Eddie Tallon, a retired Republican lawmaker in South Carolina's conservative Upstate, "but we love BMW."

In the days since White House aide Peter Navarro publicly bashed the German carmaker credited with resuscitating the local economy, GOP leaders here have faced an awkward dilemma: How do they defend the foreign firms propelling South Carolina's growth against a ruthlessly America First president?

Some have struck back at Navarro, who slammed BMW's massive Plant Spartanburg this month as a "scam" that "doesn't work for America" and is "bad for our national security." Other Republicans — such as Gov. Henry McMaster and Sens. Lindsey Graham and Tim Scott — heaped

praise on the European auto giant, which three decades ago chose this Southern community for what bloomed into its largest factory in the world.

County officials have invited President Donald Trump to visit the sprawling facility and meet some of the 11,000 South Carolinians employed there. Thus far, they've received no response. The president, they insist, should stroll the downtown no longer boarded up with plywood, thanks to the rush of overseas investment that followed BMW's splashy lead. Hundreds of companies from dozens of nations now call Spartanburg home, and most rely on a global supply chain strained by Trump's sweeping tariffs.

"Come see how much people love you here," Tallon suggested for the president at yet another grand opening. "Come see all the good things happening."

Washington's war on imports has quietly rattled manufacturing hubs across the country, as MAGA supporters express confidence in Trump's art of the deal. But the bull's eye on BMW has triggered existential dread in Spartanburg, where even residents quick to disavow "corporate greed" say they're alarmed by the administration's fixation on the 8 million-square-foot campus in their backyard.

Before South Carolina wooed the Germans with tax breaks in the early 1990s, Spartanburg was
SEE BMW ON A20

Rare-earth metals: U.S. scrambles as Beijing restricts exports. **A14**

IN THE NEWS

Pentagon procedures Defense contractors lost security clearances for lapses similar to those of Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, documents show. **A7**

Pearls of perseverance Chesapeake oysters have continued their comeback from decades of overharvesting, disease and drought. **B1**

THE NATION
An Illinois man was sentenced to life for a 2022 mass killing at a Fourth of July event. **A3**
The president's new orders on education cover civil rights rules and college accreditation. **A4**

THE WORLD
Britain, facing economic and security pressures, has nationalized its last steel mill. **A9**
Israel took responsibility for a deadly attack on a U.N. house, which it had earlier denied. **A11**

THE ECONOMY
Meta's Oversight Board ruled that two anti-trans posts did not violate its revised hate-speech rules. **A13**
Law firms are becoming increasingly vocal about pushing back on the president's demands and legal threats against them. **A15**

THE REGION
A family filed a multi-million-dollar lawsuit against a Maryland crematory that was shut down by the state. **B1**
A helicopter pilot in the Army accused of shipping LSD to buyers on the "dark web" argued that he has a religious right to do so. **B1**

STYLE
There will be no comedian at Saturday's White House correspondents' dinner. Should the event even be funny? **C1**

WEEKEND
Adrenaline junkies can find whitewater kayaking, windsurfing, rock climbing, biking and more a short drive away.

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